

Signs Worth Watching + Quiet Supports

*Practical observations and simple supports
that can protect independence longer*

After the assessment, many families want something concrete to watch for and a few practical supports they can put in place while their parent is still living alone. These are not medical recommendations. They are common, low-friction steps that families use to buy time and reduce risk.



HIGH-IMPACT AREAS

What to keep noticing + simple supports

Falls & Mobility

Signs worth watching: New near-falls, reluctance to get up from chairs, holding furniture while walking, or difficulty getting off the floor.

Quiet supports: Clear pathways, sturdy footwear, night lights on the path to the bathroom, and a simple medical alert or check-in system.

Medications

Signs worth watching: Missed doses, double doses, confusion about what a pill is for, or a growing pile of unused prescriptions.

Quiet supports: A weekly pill organizer filled together, a simple reminder system, and one trusted person who knows the current medication list.

Memory & Judgment

Signs worth watching: Getting lost in familiar places, leaving the stove on, giving money or personal information to strangers, or repeating the same questions without awareness.

Quiet supports: Increased check-in frequency, labeled important numbers by the phone, and limiting unsupervised access to large amounts of cash or new credit.

Finances & Exploitation Risk

Signs worth watching: Unpaid bills, unusual purchases, new “friends” asking for money, or confusion about bank statements.

Quiet supports: A trusted family member on the bank account for monitoring (not control), and a simple system for reviewing statements together monthly.

Emergency Response

Signs worth watching: No reliable way to call for help, infrequent check-ins, or no one who would notice quickly if something went wrong.

Quiet supports: A daily or near-daily check-in routine (phone or in-person), a medical alert device if they will wear it, and a short written list of who to call and in what order.



WHEN FAMILIES START THINKING ABOUT IT

Power of Attorney & the quiet foundations

Many families reach a point where the assessment results, plus what they keep noticing, make them start thinking about Power of Attorney. This does not mean living alone must end. It means the legal and practical foundations that protect independence are worth putting in place while decisions can still be made calmly.

Two different documents

Financial Power of Attorney lets a trusted person manage money, bills, and property if the parent cannot. Healthcare Power of Attorney (also called a healthcare proxy or medical power of attorney) lets a trusted person make medical decisions if the parent cannot speak for themselves. They are separate documents. Having one does not automatically create the other.

When families often start thinking about Financial POA

- Bills are being missed or paid late
- Confusion about bank statements, passwords, or what has already been paid
- New people asking for money or “helping” with finances in ways that feel unclear
- A hospitalization or illness made it hard to manage money for even a short time
- Adult children live in different places and need a clear legal way for one person to act

When families often start thinking about Healthcare POA

- A recent health scare or hospital stay required quick decisions
- The parent has strong wishes about medical treatment and wants them followed
- Doctors have asked who the decision-maker is and the answer was unclear
- Memory or communication changes make it harder for the parent to explain their preferences in the moment

A simple foundations checklist

A Financial Power of Attorney is signed and the agent knows where the document is kept.

A Healthcare Power of Attorney / proxy is signed and has been shared with the primary doctor.

Key family members know who holds each role and how to reach them quickly.

There is a reliable daily or near-daily check-in that someone will notice if it is missed.

A current list of medications, doctors, and pharmacy is written down and easy to find.

At least one other trusted person can access the house if needed.

These items are not a signal that living alone must end. They are the quiet infrastructure that makes living alone safer for longer — and makes any future transition far less chaotic for everyone. The heavier legal and document work can live in a larger plan. This page simply helps families notice whether the basic foundations are already present.

Life happens. Best have a plan.

Can They Live Alone?

